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Deep Pluralism as the Emerging Structure of Global Society

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INTRODUCTION

This chapter sets out the case for *deep pluralism* as the emerging structure of global society in the coming decades. The bare-bones definition of deep pluralism is a global society in which power, wealth and cultural and political authority are distributed diffusely within a system that has high interaction capacity and is strongly interdependent (Buzan 2011; Buzan and Lawson 2015; Buzan and Schouenborg 2018; Acharya and Buzan 2019). By global society, I mean a set of primary institutions in the English School sense, that operate not just in the interstate domain, but span across that and the transnational and interhuman domains (Buzan 2004, 2023). The next section sets out a general sketch of what deep

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pluralism will look like during the next one or two decades. The section following ‘[The General Character of Deep Pluralism](#)’ takes a brief look at the likely dynamics of deep pluralism in terms of its major dialectics.

THE GENERAL CHARACTER OF DEEP PLURALISM

In one sense deep pluralism is a theoretical concept about structure, and in another it is an empirical projection of global trends. In a structural theoretical sense, deep pluralism can be compared and contrasted to both the premodern structure, which also had diffuse wealth, power and cultural and political authority, but not within a system that had high interaction capacity and was strongly interdependent; and the opening phase of modernity, where wealth, power and cultural and political authority were concentrated in a small group of mainly Western states plus Japan and Russia, but within a system that had high interaction capacity and was strongly interdependent. In this sense, deep pluralism is a distinctive global system/society unlike any we have experienced before. Both ‘deep’ and ‘pluralism’ carry specific meanings. Pluralism privileges the units of the interstate system/society over global society, valuing sovereign states as a way of preserving the cultural diversity that is the legacy of human history. It favours *raison d’état* (or *raison d’empire*) over *raison de système*, and operates by a logic of coexistence within a fairly thin international society. In this context, ‘deep’ means not just a diffuse distribution of wealth and power, but also of cultural and political authority. These criteria contrast sharply with the preceding decades of Western domination and globalisation in which wealth and power, and cultural and political authority, were relatively concentrated.

In the last few decades, quite a lot of thought has gone into how to conceptualise what was agreed to be an important shift in the nature and structure of GIS. Various labels have been put forward to capture the novelty and complexity of this emergent construction: *pluri-lateralism* (Cerny 1993), *postmodern international system* (Buzan and Little 2000), *heteropolarity* (Der Derian 2003), *no one’s world* (Kupchan 2012), *multinodal* (Womack 2014), *multiplex* (Acharya 2014), *decentred globalism* (Buzan 2011), *polymorphic globalism* (Katzenstein 2012), and *multi-order world* (Flockhart 2016). This array of concepts offered different emphases in their interpretations of the shift that was underway. Some assumed globalisation to be the main trend, and so emphasised the relative disempowerment of states and the rise of non-state actors

of various kinds. Others emphasised the diffusion of wealth and power and the relative decline of the West. Most saw a more complex, multi-faceted type of world order than a simple Realist vision of a system of states jockeying for wealth and power. A reversion to the old realist idea of multipolarity could not capture the main architecture of what was happening even though there was a diffusion of power. Acharya and Buzan (2019) offered the concept of *deep pluralism*, in an attempt to aggregate the vocabulary. They noted that deep pluralism could unfold in two ways. *Contested pluralism* means that there is substantial resistance to the material and ideational reality of deep pluralism. This might take various forms: former superpowers (most obviously the US) refusing to give up their special rights and privileges; great powers refusing to recognise each other's standing, and playing against each other as rivals or enemies. *Consensual pluralism* means that the main players in GIS not only tolerate the material, cultural, ideological, and actor-type differences of deep pluralism, but also respect and even value them both as expressions of diversity, which like biodiversity is to be valued in itself, and as the foundation for coexistence (Acharya and Buzan 2019). Consensual pluralism might also be supported by a degree of intersubjective realisation of common interest in dealing with the set of inescapable shared-fate issues that increasingly confront humankind as a whole.

We are now entering into deep pluralism, and as we do so, are beginning to experience the dawn of modernity in a more truly global form, not just the Western-dominated transition of the first round of modernity. That said, empirically, we do so under the specific historical circumstances of reaction against the collapse of the short-lived heyday of neoliberalism, economic globalisation and supposed unipolarity, during which the liberal order over-extended itself. Under the imperative of neoliberalism, it pushed for a global economy that incorporated too many illiberal regimes, and whose governance mechanisms were inadequate. From a liberal perspective, there were some big gains from this experiment in terms of lowering production costs and spreading development, but some big costs too, both in destabilising the societies and politics within the liberal core, and empowering authoritarians in China and Russia. The idea that liberalism and democracy would be transplanted everywhere by the spread of capitalism proved totally wrong. Now populists both inside and outside the West want to pull down globalisation (especially economic) and reinstate the domestic/international divide in a more robust form.

The much-used term ‘emerging economies’ captures the wider array of states and societies now finding success in increasing the wealth and power they can extract from modernity. As they do so, pluralism gets both wider as more countries shift from periphery to core; and deeper, as more varieties of capitalism and modernity unfold. This is where the full picture of second-round modernity begins to crystallise, because it has now spread well beyond the founding elite, and established itself effectively in a range of societies outside the West. Multiple modernities and varieties of capitalism come into clearer meaning, as do the sustainable forms of global political economy. Now that we are actually beginning to experience deep pluralism, one can see at least some of its specific features more clearly. These are generally driven by a mix of structural logic (i.e. they could be expected in any instance of deep pluralism), and historical circumstances (i.e. arising from the particularities of the recent history that led here). There are at least five such general features, and they are not wholly mutually exclusive:

- No superpowers and strong anti-hegemonism
- Introverted great powers
- A historical legacy of post-colonial resentment, and former colonial forgetting
- Declining influence of some non-state actors
- Regionalisation.

No Superpowers and Strong Anti-Hegemonism

In much day-to-day public discourse about world politics, and even in some academic literature on current affairs, the term superpower is used in a very loose and poorly defined way. At its most ridiculous, one even hears talk of ‘regional superpowers’, which amounts to an entirely unnecessary and unhelpful inflation of meaning. There is a lot of talk of China as a rising superpower, carrying the implication that we are moving once again into a world of two superpowers (*bipolarity* in the neorealist jargon). To support a dramatic claim, going against this conventional wisdom—that we are moving into a system with no superpowers—requires clear definitions. For this purpose, I adapt and update the ones given by Buzan and Wæver (2003):

Superpowers – The criteria for superpower status are demanding in that they require broad spectrum capabilities exercised across the whole of the international system/society. Superpowers must possess first class military-political capabilities (as measured by the standards of the day), and the economies to support such capabilities. They must be capable of, and also exercise, global military and political reach. They need to see themselves, and be accepted by others in rhetoric and behaviour, as having this rank. Superpowers must be active players in processes of securitisation and desecuritisation in all, or nearly all, of the regions in the system, whether as threats, guarantors, allies or interveners. Generally, superpowers will also be fountainheads of ‘universal’ values of the type necessary to underpin international society. Their legitimacy as superpowers will depend substantially on their success in establishing the legitimacy of such values. Taking all of these factors into account, during the nineteenth century Britain, France and more arguably Russia had this rank. After the First World War, it was held by Britain, the US and the Soviet Union. After the Second World War it was held by the US and the Soviet Union. After the Cold War it was held only by the US. The US is just about still the sole superpower, though its leadership legitimacy and ideological credibility are fraying fast. China is not yet in a position to treat the world as its region or to be accepted as a superpower.

Great Powers – Achieving great power status is less demanding in terms of both capability and behaviour. Great powers need not necessarily have big capabilities in all sectors. Neither do they need to be actively present in the securitisation processes of all areas of the international system, though they do need to be a significant factor beyond their own region. Great power status rests mainly on a single key: what distinguishes great powers from merely regional ones is that they are responded to by others on the basis of system-level calculations about the present and near future distribution of power. This might imply that a great power is treated in the calculations of other major powers as if it has the clear economic, military and political potential to bid for superpower status in the short or medium term, but great powers are sufficient in themselves to affect global calculations, and they may of course be declining superpowers. This single key is observable in the foreign policy processes and discourses of other powers. It means that actual possession of material and legal attributes is less crucial for great powers than for superpowers. Great powers will usually have appropriate levels of capability, though even before China could meet that standard it demonstrated an impressive ability over nearly a century to trade on future capabilities that it had yet to fully deliver (Segal 1999). They will generally think of themselves as more than regional powers, and possibly

as prospective superpowers, and they will be capable of operating in more than one region. But while these characteristics will be typical of great powers they are not strictly speaking necessary so long as other powers treat them as potential superpowers. Occasionally, a declining power will be given honorary great power status.

Regional Powers - Regional powers define the polarity of any given RSC [regional security complex]: unipolar, as in Southern Africa, bipolar in South Asia, multipolar as in the Middle East, South America and South-east Asia. Their capabilities loom large in their regions, but do not register much in a broad-spectrum way at the global level. Higher level powers respond to them as if their influence and capability were mainly relevant to the securitisation processes of a particular region. They are thus excluded from the higher level calculations of system polarity whether or not they think of themselves as deserving a higher ranking...

In a general sense, the very definition of deep pluralism, with its emphasis on the diffusion of wealth, power and political and cultural authority, leans against the idea of there being one or more superpowers within it. Superpower status depends on one or more states being able to acquire disproportionate weight within the system. I have also argued that as modernity spreads, it will fuel a strong anti-hegemonism, stemming partly from reaction against the two-century hegemony of the first-round modernisers (and in particular fuelled by post-colonial resentment against them on which more below), and partly from the fact that rising powers generally cultivate anti-hegemonic attitudes. Since many are rising as the second round widens and deepens, and since the first-round modernisers are not going away (they are mainly in relative, not absolute, decline), it will necessarily be difficult, if not impossible, for the US to retain superpower status, or China to reach it. Indeed, the US seems to be losing the political will, and the support of its electorate, to play the superpower role, and a reasonable case can be made that China does not want the role. Unlike the US, which projects 'universal' values, and thinks everyone should become like America, China's exceptionalism is much more inward looking, stressing its uniqueness by the frequent use of the term 'Chinese characteristics' (Cui and Buzan 2016). The prospect is of a world of several great powers and many regional ones. The US and China might well be *primus inter pares*, but they will not be superpowers.

In a technical sense, this system might look multipolar, and that will be the context in which any cooperation on great power management

of global society has to be approached. But because of strong anti-hegemonic sentiments it is unlikely to feature the Realist type struggle to dominate the whole system normally associated with the idea of multipolarity. What is emerging will be novel in a number of respects. Increasingly, power, wealth and cultural and ideological authority will be wielded by non-Western as well as Western actors (Buzan and Lawson 2015; Acharya and Buzan 2019). Although they are all embedded in a highly interdependent global economy, and a single planetary environment, none wants to, or can, lead or dominate GIS. It seems likely that while the US and China will be *primus inter pares*, they will not be in an entirely different class from India, the EU, and possibly Russia, Brazil and Japan. They will be great powers in the sense that their influence extends beyond their own regions, and that they have to be taken into account at the global level, but the world will not be their region in the sense of the definition given above, and therefore neither will be a superpower. Their contest seems to be more about adjusting spheres of influence in Asia, and about bringing the US down a peg or two in its pretensions to global primacy and leadership. It does not, at least in the short and medium term, or possibly the long term, look like a contest for global primacy.

Indeed, under emerging deep pluralism, the very idea of global hegemonic leadership, which has been closely associated with Western hegemony for more than two centuries, seems likely to be delegitimised. Such a world will feature different economic and political ideologies and systems, including the remnants of the liberal order. This will be a novel system/society, and not only because we have got used to living in a GIS with a high concentration of power dominated by superpowers.

Introverted Great Powers

The argument that deep pluralism will look like a multipolar system, but not behave as one, is reinforced by the fact that the particular historical conditions of this transition point in modernity, suggest that all of the likely great powers will be introverted in their outlook and behaviour. Nothing in the theory says that deep pluralist systems are necessarily populated by introverted great powers, though the diffusion of wealth, power and authority perhaps make that more likely than not. The concept of ‘autistic’ great powers has been around in the IR literature for a long time. In states it can be understood as where reaction to external inputs

is based much more on the internal processes of the state—its domestic political bargains, party rivalries, pandering to public opinion (whether it be nationalist or isolationist), and suchlike—than on rational, fact-based, assessment of and engagement with the other states and societies that constitute international society (Senghaas 1974; Buzan 2007; Luttwak 2012). To some extent ‘autism’ in this sense is a normal feature of states. It is built into their political structure that domestic factors generally take first priority, whether because that is necessary for regime survival, or because the government is designed in such a way as to represent its citizens’ interests. Autism, however, is a complex phenomenon, and its use as an analogy may not be the ideal way to capture the fairly simple quality of introversion and self-referenced behaviour in states.

There is a growing interest in the new great powers and their roles and responsibilities in international society (Gaskarth 2015; Falkner and Buzan 2021). Introversion will be strong in the current and near future set of great powers for two reasons. First, the old, advanced industrial great powers (the US, the EU, Japan) are not going to go away, but they are exhausted, weakened both materially and in terms of legitimacy, and are increasingly unable or unwilling to take the lead. No clearer illustration of this could be desired than the surprising 2016 successes in attracting voter support of both the Brexit campaign in the UK, and Trump’s ‘America first’ campaign in the US (Buzan and Cox). The EU has weak foreign and security policy institutions anyway, and is too mired in its own local problems of the Euro, Brexit, migration, Turkey and Russia to have much diplomatic energy or legitimacy left for *raison de système*. It is barely maintaining *raison de région*. Japan is preoccupied with recovering its status as a ‘normal country’ and trying to deal with the rapid rise of a China that seems committed to maintaining historical hostility against it. The rising great powers (China and India, possibly Brazil) are very keen to claim great power status, and might provide new blood to the great power camp. But they are equally keen not to let go of their status as developing countries. They want to assert their own cultures against the long dominance of the West, and some, notably China, are cultivating a nationalism based on historical grievance. But while they know what they are against, the rising powers have as yet shown little clear idea about what kind of alternative GIS they want. That combination leads them to give priority to their own development. They argue, not unreasonably, that their own development is a big and difficult

job for them, and that developing their own big populations is a sufficient contribution to GIS in itself. On that basis, they resist being given wider global managerial responsibilities. Russia is not a rising power, and is too weak, too unpopular, too self-centred and too stuck in an imperial mind-set, to take a consensual global leadership role. The cycle of prickly action–overreaction relations typical of introversion is already visible in US–China, Russia–EU, US–Russia and China–Japan relations.

Great powers are in part defined by their wider responsibilities to *raison de système*. If, as seems likely, it becomes accepted that developing countries can also rank as great powers, then the general consequence will be a granting of great power rights to more states, alongside a reduction in great power responsibilities. To the extent that states, and especially great powers, have introverted foreign policies, they not only fail to uphold *raison de système*, but also lose touch with their social environment, and are blind to how their policies and behaviours affect the way that others see and react to them. In such conditions a cycle of prickly action–overreaction is likely to prevail, and building trust becomes difficult or impossible. Everyone sees only their own interests, concerns and ‘rightness’, and is blind to the interests, concerns and ‘rightness’ of others. If this diagnosis turns out to be correct, then we are unlikely to see responsible great powers. The absence of responsible great powers in conditions of deep pluralism points to a contested deep pluralist GIS, weak, and possibly quite fractious. Russia is the most extreme exemplar of a great power putting *raison d’état* first, and caring little about *raison de système*. China seems to be abandoning its earlier position of peaceful rise/development, and following the Russian playbook of bullying neighbours and cultivating victimhood nationalism. China and Japan, with their unresolved history problem, make a classic case of introverted relations (Buzan and Goh 2020), and China’s relations with India seem headed in the same direction. The US and China are pushed more towards contested deep pluralism by domestic political imperatives: seeking domestic unity in the face of a challenger to US primacy for the US; hardening and sealing itself to reduce outside influence and consolidate CCP control, in the case of China.

Introverted great powers means that the exercise of great power management responsibility under deep pluralism will be more diffuse and more complicated than under the relatively concentrated domination of the US over the last few decades, or the relative simplicity of the bipolar Cold War. One factor is the wider diversity of great powers created by the

rise of China, India and others. Developed/developing is one element of this, but there are other ways of parsing this issue. Cui and Buzan (2016), for example, explore an ideological spectrum ranging from universal, open and inclusive polities (e.g. pre-Trump US, Canada, Brazil), to parochial, closed and exclusive ones (e.g. China, Japan, Israel). Such ideological differentiations mattered during both the interwar and Cold War years. They may well matter again under deep pluralism, where there will not only be a divide between authoritarians and democracies, but also one between the different civilizational values represented by the US, Europe, Russia, China, India and the Islamic World. Both the likely rise in prominence of the regional level as compared with the global one, and the impact of empowered post-colonial resentment, could also play strongly into great power differentiation. More on these below.

Post-colonial Resentment and Metropolitan Forgetting

The third predictable quality of emerging deep pluralism is that it will sit on top of a very tricky and corrosive history problem composed, on the one hand, of a large reservoir of post-colonial resentment in those seeing themselves as victims of colonialism, and on the other, of a mixture of forgetting, ignorance and denial, among the former metropolises (Buzan and Goh 2020). The existence of this history problem is a historically particular effect of the monocentric route to globalisation. The uneven but combined development that took over with such force during the first round of modernity came in a colonial, core–periphery, form in which one civilisation, itself fragmented into competing states, subjugated all the others, and, with much ruthlessness and coercion, imposed many of its social and material forms on them. Colonialism came along with political subjugation, economic exploitation, cultural disrespect, scientific superiority, and racial inequality and discrimination. It also came along with elements of development, but these were generally pitched towards the needs and concerns of the individual metropolitan powers. Railways and ports were built mainly to extract resources from the colonies, open their markets to the manufactures of the metropole, and sometimes to facilitate mass migrations. As noted above, even Japan’s noteworthy industrialisations of Korea and Manchuria were done to extend its imperial core, not to benefit the locals.

The experience of colonialism unsurprisingly left a deep and powerful resentment within almost all countries that experienced it, and that resentment is now a major part of what the Global South brings to the table as inputs from the non-West into thinking about, and practising, international relations (Zarakol 2011; Acharya and Buzan 2019; Buzan and Acharya 2022). Hodgson (1993) nicely captures the humiliation in the ‘sense of radical spiritual defeat’ that the encounter with the power and ideas of the modernising West inflicted on the Islamic world and China. It was a blow to their inner prestige to have their sense of being the dominant world civilisation so rudely and abruptly displaced. Post-colonial resentment against the racism, coercion and cultural contempt of the colonial West and Japan is not going to disappear any time soon. Indeed, as the second round of modernity unfolds, the new wealth and power, and recovered cultural and political authority, of the Global South are increasingly linked to this still strongly felt post-colonial resentment. To get a measure of this one has only to look at the importance China still attaches not only to reproducing the memory of its ‘century of humiliation’, but also to making it an active factor in its day-to-day foreign and domestic policy. It comes up everywhere in the post-colonial Global South, from demands for aid as a form of reparations; through insistence on unequal responsibilities for the legacy polluters of the first round of modernisation in taking on the burdens of controlling climate change; to claims for the return of cultural objects looted or appropriated by the former colonial powers. Such claims certainly need to be addressed, but inept leaders in the Global South still can, and do, make good political use of blaming colonisation for their own shortcomings in achieving development.

By contrast, while public opinion in the liberal West remains sensitive to racism and slavery in its domestic spheres and histories, it has largely forgotten about, marginalised or denied the racism and coercion it exercised against other peoples during the imperial era. The ‘black lives matter’ movement going strong at the time of writing not only exemplifies this selective sensitivity, but the distinctive American version of it which associated slavery and race much more strongly than was generally the case everywhere else during the premodern era. So while there are, to be sure, ongoing campaigns against historical racism and slavery within the West, there are at the same time white nationalists and neo-fascists re-legitimising racism in relation to contemporary migration. Many in the West and Japan have forgotten, or are ignorant, about the colonial history of their countries, and some promote counter-narratives of the colonial

period as a mainly successful civilising mission. The particular forms and patterns of this history problem vary from country to country, but overall there remains a huge and politically volatile gap between former colonised and colonisers about how to understand their shared history (Buzan and Goh 2020).

When Hedley Bull (1984) worried about the Third Worlds' 'revolt against the West' nearly forty years ago, that revolt could still be, and largely was, ignored by the West, because the newly decolonised states and peoples behind it were mostly poor, weak and culturally emasculated. The West largely satisfied itself with some commitment to give foreign aid to the Third World in the hope that development along liberal lines would somehow be easy and automatic. Modernisation theory assumed that modernisation effectively meant Westernisation (Spruyt 2020). Now, substantial parts of the former periphery are growing strong, and knocking on the door of the core. They are finding, or in some cases such as China, South Korea, Taiwan and Singapore, have already found, their own paths to modernity, and they are not clones of the West, but distinctive syntheses between their traditional cultures and modernity. Their historical grievances against the West and Japan can no longer be side-lined.

Coming to terms with the legacy of colonialism is necessary to the construction of a viable, deeply pluralist, global society capable of dealing with the rising tide of shared threats. Reconciling this colonial past will not be easy for either side, though the widespread acceptance of human and racial equality should help. The West and Japan need to acknowledge their role, and accommodate the sense of grievance and humiliation in the former colonial world. But the former colonial world also needs to acknowledge its own responsibilities and complicities. Colonialism was certainly a story of ruthlessly exploited inequality, but it was not a simple dyad between colonisers and colonised, exploiters and exploited. Until the late eighteenth century, for example, slavery was a normal practice in every major culture. Collaboration was also a big part of the story from Korea to Africa; and as the contrast between Japan's and China's responses to the Western challenge show, colonised and/or exploited countries bear some responsibility for their own weakness and vulnerability (Gray 2002). China resisted modernity so successfully during the nineteenth century that it made itself weak and vulnerable to outside powers (Wang 2019). The Islamic world likewise proved unable to adapt itself to modernity

quickly enough to prevent widespread colonisation by the West, and fragmentation into Western-style states (Piscatori 1986). The highly uneven onset, development and spread of modernity initially divided the world into core and periphery. As modernity now becomes more widespread and more culturally differentiated, the huge gaps in wealth, power and cultural and political authority opened during the nineteenth century are beginning to close (Findlay and O'Rourke 2007; Buzan and Lawson 2015).

If reconciliation occurs, it will have to be a two-way street in which both sides will need to examine their own faults as well as those of the other side. As wealth, power and cultural and political authority become more widely diffused in global society, the legacy of colonialism could easily poison diplomacy, push deep pluralism more towards conflictual mode, and impede functional cooperation on shared-threat issues such as climate change and disease control, and the process of reforming IGOs. How this history problem is handled by both sides, will be one key determinant of whether deep pluralism is more contested or more consensual.

Declining Influence of Some Non-state Actors

Many of the discussions noted above that tried to capture the nature of the emerging new world order, took the view that non-state actors would play an expanding role alongside states. Nonstate actors ranging across the spectrum from civil (e.g. Red Cross/Crescent, *Médecins Sans Frontières*, some transnational firms), to uncivil (e.g. Islamic State, organised crime), with many in between (e.g. Facebook, mercenary companies, proselytising religions, other transnational firms) would become prominent players in global society. States would probably remain the dominant form of actor, but much more entangled in webs of global governance than is implied in the term multipolarity. There would be many non-state actors in play in global society, some of which would wield significant amounts of wealth, power and authority. The transnational domain would become more equal to the interstate one in the composition of global society. That view reflected the strength of arguments about globalisation and global governance in the discussion of IR during the two decades following the end of the Cold War. Until quite recently, I agreed with that assumption. But with deep pluralism now unfolding in front of us, it is necessary to question it. The idea rests on the calculation that both

firms and INGOs will continue on the upward track of diplomatic prominence that they have been building through much of the first round of modernity. Firms are now ubiquitous across the global capitalist system in both democracies and authoritarian states, and will probably be able to maintain, if not improve, their position.

INGOs, however, are more precariously placed, and might be set to decline for the duration of deep pluralism. Unlike the relatively even distribution of firms, global civil society (GCC) was always heavily associated with the INGOs of the West, and served to enhance Western dominance by projecting Western values (Clark 2007; Hurrell 2007; Armstrong 1998). Western INGOs both rode on the back of Western power, and the universalising thrust of liberal teleology, and reinforced it. As the West becomes just one core of wealth, power and cultural and political authority among several, and the liberal teleology loses its force, it seems a fair bet that the influence of GCC actors will decline. In a sense, democracy and the liberal teleology are back in the 1930s, facing both an internal crisis of legitimacy (inequality, financial crisis, unemployment) and being surrounded by an array of powerful populist, authoritarian and even neo-fascist regimes that are in competition with them. The key difference is that the threat from outside is not mainly of military invasion, because the risks of great power war are now too high. Neither does capitalism itself seem much threatened by alternative ideologies. Now the challenge is more about the direct and indirect subversion of open societies, which is difficult to counter without the necessary measures themselves undermining open societies and the non-state actors that flourish within them.

China as a rising power does not look at all likely to generate its own stable of independent INGOs to throw into the ring. Authoritarian regimes in general do not provide fertile ground for independent non-state actors. Like the Soviet Union, they may try to put forward their own front organisations, but these are hardly likely to be accepted as genuine representatives from the transnational domain. The influence of INGOs will not disappear, but it might well be more confined to the sphere of liberal democratic states. What had looked, during the later decades of the first round of modernity, like a movement towards the diversification of the actors engaged in diplomacy across the board, and therefore towards a kind of diplomacy for global society, rather than for global interstate society, may well slow down or stall for the duration of deep pluralism. In principle, deep pluralism should not be a friendly environment for

INGOs, and in practice there is both a weakening of their support base in the West, and a hostile environment of post-colonial resentment against Western liberal values. The one exception to this will probably be militant non-state actors, which look set to be mainstream participants in war and diplomacy.

Regionalisation

Regionalisation is a relatively recent development in international relations. The regional level thus did not really come into its own worldwide until decolonisation created autonomous subsystems of states, first in the Americas, and after the Second World War in South and Southeast Asia, the Middle East and Africa. Even then it was constrained by superpower overlay during the Cold War, and up to a point thereafter by US primacy and globalisation. The relative decline of the US and Western dominance during the first two decades of the twenty-first century, and the move into deep pluralism, would seem to offer good prospects for a more regionalised global society.

The definition of deep pluralism suggests favourable conditions for what might be thought of as a subsystem-dominant form of international system/society. The diffusion of wealth, power and cultural and political authority on the one hand, and the absence of superpowers treating the world as their region, on the other, both open up space for regional dynamics to gain more autonomy and prominence. But is that the way things will unfold? In relation to this question, a lot hangs on how the relationship between China and the US works out. If mainstream opinion is right, and deep pluralism becomes dominated by a globe-spanning superpower rivalry between the US and China, then, as during the Cold War, the autonomy of regional dynamics will be compromised by degrees of overlay, in which the global-level rivalry of two superpowers penetrates and dominates more local dynamics. The main question marks hanging over this scenario arise from the domestic politics in the US and China. In the US, the rise of Trumpism left the legitimacy of US claims to global leadership deeply in doubt, and damaged many of the secondary institutions that supported it. If, as seems likely at the time of writing, Trumpism remains a powerful force in US domestic politics, the stability of the US's will and capability to play a superpower role are in serious question. In the case of China, one has to reflect on the longstanding self-centredness of Chinese politics, in which concerns about its domestic order far outweigh

concerns about foreign relations. Luttwak (2012) argues that China is the most autistic of the great powers, not least because it is the biggest. Recall that during the 1930s and 1940s, the main political actors in China were, for most of the time, far more concerned about the civil war among them than about resisting Japanese imperialism. China seems more likely to remain relatively inward looking in this way, than to want to be running the world.

If I am right, and the US and China are not superpowers treating the world as their region, but merely big great powers, then there is considerable scope for a more regionalised global society. In that case, the US–China rivalry would be mainly about spheres of influence in Asia, and not, as the US–Soviet rivalry was, a contest to dominate the planet. In a no-superpower scenario of deep pluralism, many of the emerging powers would have as much or more focus on their own regions, and their position within them, as they would on the global level. When superpowers dominated the system, global-level concerns generally trumped regional-level ones. But in a world of several great and many regional powers, the regional level could well become more autonomous. China has some global aspirations, but its main immediate concern is to gain primacy in Asia. Russia, India and Brazil want recognition as great powers, but are mainly interested in their own regions and those immediately adjacent. If regional dynamics become stronger relative to global ones, then many different models will come into play. The observation of Buzan and Wæver (2003) about the relationship between regions and great powers remains salient here. Regions vary hugely in how they relate to great powers. Some are heavily dominated by a single great power within them (North America, South Asia, the former Soviet Union, possibly South America). Some have created substantial institutional frameworks to mediate their affairs (Europe). Some have more than one great power within them (East Asia). And some have no great powers within them (Africa, the Middle East). Great powers can and do intervene in adjacent regions (China in South and Southeast Asia; Europe and Russia in the Middle East; Europe in Africa). For the most part, great powers can no longer simply exploit their local preponderance to maintain regional order. They need to negotiate with their neighbours and regional powers. As the transition towards a post-Western deep pluralism progresses, the waning of superpowers should raise the relative autonomy of the regional level, and the regional dynamics with internal and adjacent great powers.

On this basis, we might anticipate that under deep pluralism, great powers will operate on two levels, global and regional. On the global level, the extent and character of cooperation/conflict will depend on whether deep pluralism is more contested or more consensual. That, in turn, depends on how a complex conjuncture of factors plays out. How will the great powers respond to the various shared-fate threats, such as climate change and pandemics that affect them all? How deeply will post-colonial resentment poison relations between first- and second-round modernisers? Will great power rivalries over spheres of influence disrupt their ability to cooperate? The key danger here is that the global level will remain undermanaged because a more regionalised global society will draw interest and attention away from the global level. On the regional level, there is likely to be quite considerable diversity in how great powers operate. That diversity will be partly generated by different structures, and partly by different foundations of cultural authority. On one end of the spectrum will be Europe, with its relatively strong and consensual regional institutional framework which is still in a class of its own even after Brexit. On the other end will be the spheres around Russia and China, both of which seem to be seeking primacy over their regions, and tending to think a bit like empires. Southeast Asia has elements of both regional institutionalisation and local great power dominance. Regions with no internal great powers—the Middle East and Africa—will either be left more to their own affairs, or intervened in by neighbouring great powers if they become securitised by them. The issue of migration from Africa and the Middle East to Europe is a current example of that securitising dynamic. In my reading, the odds favour a deep pluralism with a strong regional level. The global level will be generally weakened as a result. Part of that will be a long contestation over the reshaping of secondary institutions to accommodate the new realities of wealth, power and cultural and political authority in a global society with no superpowers and no guiding ideology. The key question is whether the pressure of shared-fate threats will be enough to sustain specific forms of global GPM adequate to deal with them (Acharya and Buzan 2019).

Conclusions

There is a considerable amount of inertia behind the move into deep pluralism. Structural shifts such as the wider distribution of wealth, power, and cultural and political authority, the fading out of superpowers, and

the rise of regionalism, are hard to stop. Points of historical baggage such as introverted great powers, post-colonial resentment and the normative crisis of liberalism and its teleology, also run deep. Lumped together, this appears to create a powerful push towards the contested form of deep pluralism as something that will happen regardless of whether the US–China rivalry turns out to be global or inter-regional. As the second round of modernity delivers more states into the core, displacing Western dominance, but not eliminating the West as a major centre of wealth, power and influence, the prospect is one of a more decentred international order. Liberalism will become just one of a number of forms of modernity in play, and no longer provide the dominant teleology. A larger and more diverse core of powers at the leading edge of modernity points towards a looser and more contested global order. The evening-out of modernity will, perhaps for some decades, put the brakes on what seemed to be the momentum of the first round of modernity towards ever-greater economic, social and political globalisation. Yet inertial drift is not the whole story of deep pluralism. There are also contradiction and dialectics on the social structure and material conditions on deep pluralism that need to be taken into account.

THE DYNAMICS OF DEEP PLURALISM IN TERMS OF PRIMARY INSTITUTIONS

The first round of modernity was hugely successful in intensifying globalisation by improving both physical and social interaction capacity. But its drive for economic globalisation went too far too fast, once again crashing into the fragmenting logics of sovereignty, territoriality and nationalism, and so far failing to overcome them. The dialectic between the global market and economic nationalism therefore looks set to continue, and may be of the *zhongyong* type that remains durable rather than unfolding towards some resolution (Qin 2018). Even China, perhaps the most autarchically inclined of the great powers, seems to recognise that orderly global trading is necessary, and that this requires cooperation on rules for trade, investment and finance. The second round of modernity inherits the dynamics of that contradiction, but also confronts the new, and rapidly burgeoning one of environmental globalisation. Economic and environmental globalisation are of course related, with the former being a principal dynamic giving rise to the latter. Either kind of globalisation challenges the fragmenting logics of global society. The big question is

therefore whether environmental globalisation will hit the same buffers as the economic kind, failing to break through to a more integrated form of global society? Economic globalisation was to a considerable extent a choice. Some, of course, had it rammed down their throats during the first round of modernity, but others, most notably China under Deng, chose it on the grounds that its developmental benefits outweighed its costs even for a government determined to retain a Leninist state. Environmental globalisation will not be a choice in the sense that one can opt in or opt out. Whether in terms of a shift to planetary management, or as a shared experience of environmental deterioration, all will confront environmental globalisation whether they like it or not.

In terms of the contradictions and dialectics going forward into deep pluralism, three observations stand out.

First, is that there looks to be a major island of stability comprising the strong mutually reinforcing cluster of primary institutions around the modern state: sovereignty, territoriality, nationalism, diplomacy and international law. This cluster is strong not only because the institutions are mutually supporting, but also because the principle ones—sovereignty, territoriality, nationalism—have deep roots across the three domains. This is the core support for the argument that there will be a lot of continuity in the structure of global society going forward. This cluster of institutions is mainly about how global society is internally differentiated and fragmented, and what makes it a social structure is that this set of principles of differentiation and fragmentation is widely agreed as legitimate. All of these institutions look robust in themselves, and their mutual support makes them stronger. This is the bedrock of the anarchical society. War in its traditional, mainly military, sense was part of this package during the first round of modernity, but has weakened and dissipated so much as an institution (less so as a practice, where it has become more diverse and diffuse) that it will probably have much less shaping influence on the second round. Development might also count as part of this package on the grounds that it seems likely to remain a strong primary institution given that uneven development is unlikely to disappear soon as a collective problem for global society. Development is often embodied in the form of developmental states in both core and periphery, and so fits with this core package. All of the major powers, and most of the lesser ones, seem firmly in support of this anarchical society.

The second observation is also about continuity, but in a more paradoxical way: that many of the contradictions and dialectics that opened

up during the first round of modernity will remain ongoing in defining the second round.

- The dialectic between the market and economic nationalism remains vigorous, and shows no signs of coming to an end.
- The multifaceted dialectic between human equality and inequality (in terms of racism, slavery, patriarchy, wealth), and the related contestation over the nature of human rights, likewise show no signs of coming to an end any time soon, if ever.
- The dialectic between religion/mysticism (faith and revealed ‘knowledge’) and science (evidence and rational argument) seems to have reached a kind of draw, with neither able to eliminate the other, and their contradiction fought out issue by issue, as most recently with Covid-19.

These three feel like they are *zhongyong* dialectics, not just taking a while to resolve, but almost permanent contradictions needing to be managed according to the evolving conditions of the day. Perhaps these *zhongyong* style dialectics are a characteristic of modernity’s general turbulence.

A fourth ongoing dialectic is that between development and environmental stewardship. This certainly had roots in the first round of modernity, but might better be thought of as the distinctive dialectic of the second round. The contradiction is between the ongoing pressure for the pursuit of human empowerment, and the rising pressure from shared fates, some of which are driven by that pursuit. The Covid-19 pandemic has illustrated the mounting threat from environmental issues interplaying with the Anthropocene, and the problem of climate change is not far behind. There is thus a powerful meta-dialectic emerging in the second round of modernity between environmental integration/interdependence on the one hand, and fragmentation (sovereignty, identity, territoriality) on the other. This dialectic is inherently unpredictable inasmuch as it cannot be known which shared-fate issue(s) will generate a global crisis, when this will happen, and in what form. Neither can it be known how the availability, or not, of new technologies, especially digital and biological ones, will play into these developments. The general nature of the problems and threats posed by pandemics, sea-level rise, extreme weather, mass migrations, etc., are reasonably knowable, but the details, timings and placings are not. Will such issues deepen divisions and

become weaponised as part of the armouries of rivalry in a contested deep pluralism? Or will they inspire, or necessitate, global cooperation and a change of mindset about the priorities of global society, moving deep pluralism towards a more consensual form?

This dialectic has a clear potential resolution in the concept of sustainable development, but the outcome remains uncertain. Sustainable development might be achieved, offering a way forward for the continued unfolding of human empowerment within modernity. Or the contradiction between unrestrained attempts to increase human empowerment might be pushed to an environmental crisis and regression of the human species. Given the link of development to the cluster of primary institutions supporting the anarchical society, this might also be understood as the defining meta-dialectic of second-round modernity: the anarchical society package on the one hand, and economic and environmental globalisation/deterritorialisation one on the other. From that perspective, we might expect this meta-dialectic to open up more powerfully than before the longstanding contradiction between *national security* (security against) and *common security* (security with). This contradiction is not new, but it looks set to become particularly intense in the coming decades. Although the imperatives of ‘security against’ are still in robust play in world politics, the imperatives of ‘security with’ are gaining ground as shared threats from pandemics and global warming to terrorism, mass migration and proliferation of weapons of mass destruction, increasingly impinge on global society. These provide a new and unprecedented set of circumstances in which a less deterministic view of power politics, and a more open view of the interplay of anarchy and hierarchy, might be both useful and necessary. Shared fates support a turn towards the principle of common security meaning that security ‘with’ might become more important than security ‘against’ (Buzan and Hansen 2009).

The third observation is a negative one. Nothing in the analysis given above suggests either that new primary institutions or new contradictions/dialectics, are about to open up along the path of human empowerment. If this is true, then the second round of modernity will proceed along the familiar dynamics set up by the first. The one obvious objection to this argument is that humankind may, in the coming decades, confront itself either with species differentiation (biotech) or rival forms of intelligence (AI). Such developments could redefine the meaning of humanism to be about the preservation of the mark-1 human

being against superior rivals. But rather than creating a new contradiction/dialectic, such developments would simply add another layer to the existing, already elaborate, one about human (in)equality.

The major key to the second round of modernity is how global society will respond to, and be shaped by, the rising pressure from shared-fate threats. Humankind is perhaps unlucky in having to face this dialectic from a starting point defined by a deep pluralism that has arisen for myriad reasons other than the emerging dialectic with the planetary carrying capacity. There is a real danger in this that environmental crises will reinforce contested pluralism in a way that forestalls an adequate collective response to the shared threat. That outcome is not inevitable, for as illustrated by US and Soviet cooperation on arms control during the Cold War, even contested deep pluralism does not exclude a degree of GPM on specific functional issues such as shared-fate threats.

There are also possibilities, perhaps less likely, that the rising shared threat from the environment will hasten the turning of the deep pluralism supertanker. This could either be towards a more consensual deep pluralism, which would make cooperation on the environment easier, or towards some new form of political and economic globalisation aimed at making species responsibility for management of the planet the first priority of global society. Either of these moves is likely only if (a) the impacts of the environmental crisis on humankind and its civilisation intensify, and (b) if there is some common understanding of the threat and what needs to be done about it. We are likely to get (a) whether we want it or not, so the key is in what direction those impacts push global society: towards everyone for themselves, or towards degrees of collective action. That is where the scope for agency lies in the second round of modernity. Having globalised the economy and the environment, the next task of modernity is to find a way of globalising humankind sufficiently to enable it to operate and survive on a planetary scale.

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